

FACT

India's ancient Sanskrit language dates back to at least 1500 BCE, and was spoken in royal courts. Prakrit was spoken by everyday people as Sanskrit was considered too sophisticated.

A cupola (small dome) tops the pyramid.



▲ BUDDHISM

According to Buddhist tradition, Siddhartha Gautama, known as the Buddha, was born a prince around 560 BCE in modern-day Nepal. He left the palace and was shocked by the poverty he saw. He vowed to live a simpler life and spent the rest of his days teaching others how to overcome suffering. The religion of Buddhism, based on his teachings, now has more than 500 million followers around the world.

◀ STONE ARCHITECTURE

The Pallavas were a dynasty of kings that ruled south India from the late 3rd century CE. They constructed many monuments—at first these were cut into the sides of mountains, but later the Pallavas developed methods of creating free-standing temples from stone. The Shore Temple at Mamallapuram, Tamil Nadu, is their greatest architectural achievement.

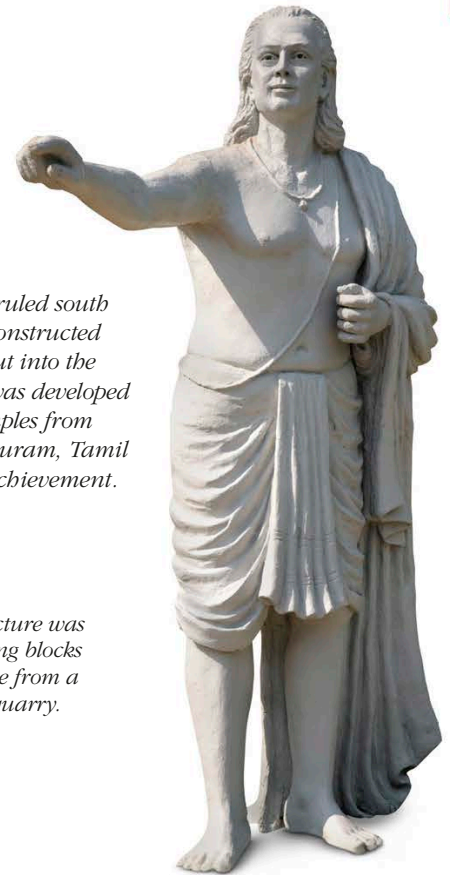
The structure was built using blocks of granite from a nearby quarry.

TAKE A LOOK

Ayurveda is an ancient Indian system of medicine that was first practiced in the 1st millennium BCE and is still popular today. It involves meditation, yoga, massage, and herbal treatments for illnesses. The people who practice it believe that the prevention of disease is better than a cure.



BEFORE 500 CE



▲ GOLDEN AGE

The reign of the Guptas was a time of great progress in math, science, philosophy, and the arts. In the 6th century CE, the mathematician Aryabhata (above) was one of the first people to understand the importance of the number zero.